

been no appreciable loss of what, for want of a better term, I would call American "product prestige."

The proofs of all this are plain enough to anyone who lives or travels abroad with open eyes and an open mind.

Most of the world outside the Iron Curtain happily sips American cola and hopes some day to own a Sheaffer pen.

American automobiles are still status symbols for those who own them in foreign countries—and so are American refrigerators, washing machines, TV sets and a host of other items. Arrow shirts, Colgate toothpaste, Gillette razors and blades—these and a thousand and one other American trade-marked products are high on the preferred lists of foreign shoppers. In Communist countries, even such commonplace American-made items as ballpoint pens, lipsticks and nylon stockings fetch black-market prices ten or more times their open-market cost. Any American who has resided abroad for any length of time knows what it is to be bombarded by requests that he order this or that item from the States.

The demand is there—have no doubt about that. Foreign markets are wide open to the enterprising American businessman—more so now than ever before because the

41

wealth and buying power of people in many foreign lands have multiplied many times in the last decade.

"But we can't compete with foreign manufacturers," a U.S. industrialist complained to me recently. "They can always undersell us."

First of all, it's not true that foreign manufacturers can

"always" undersell American producers. Take just two random examples. American coal, mined by highly paid American miners, is sold in a great many parts of Europe at a lower price than English coal, which is produced by English miners who earn far less than their U.S. counterparts. An Italian-